

SABNOCK WORKS

WHEN FEAR OF AI TURNS INTO HATE

On Artists' Rights, Economic Uncertainty, and the Decision to Help Shape Change



Imprint and Copyright

English edition

Published by Sabnock Works

Michael Kahler

Kattrepel 7

27404 Zeven

sabnockworks.com

Copyright © 2026 Sabnock Works. All rights reserved.

Version 1/2026

Research was supported by ChatGPT-5.6 Sol.

The exposé was written by Michael Kahler.

The draft was edited by Michael Kahler.

The cover image was AI-generated by OpenAI.

Contents

01 Why the Conflict Becomes So Personal

02 Artists' Legitimate Objection

03 Why Prices and Self-Image Come Under Pressure

04 When Outrage Takes Over the Discussion

05 Helping Shape Change Creates Agency

06 Our Attitude Shows in Our Work

1. Why the Conflict Becomes So Personal

In a creative project, the mere mention of AI is sometimes enough to bring discussion of the actual work to an end. Instead of game mechanics or design, the legitimacy of the working method is now debated. In one discussion on r/indiegames, for example, users call for immediate bans because of AI artwork. The moderation team of r/gamedev, by contrast, explicitly takes the position that posts should be judged by their content and that AI assistance should not automatically be equated with low quality. These examples document differing attitudes. They do not show a representative distribution of opinion among players.

For artists, the same debate can be a very concrete economic question. Hui, Reshef, and Zhou examined the short-term effects of generative AI on a freelance platform and found negative effects in services that were especially exposed. The authors report corresponding developments after the introduction of both text systems and image generators. The study does not allow a prediction about the end of creative professions. It does, however, make clear that concerns about commissions have a real basis.

I therefore distinguish between concern, protest, and personal hostility. Anyone who criticises training practices or wishes to support exclusively human-made art is taking a legitimate position. Anyone who insults a developer because they use a particular tool must be judged by their own conduct. That is an ethical assessment made by this essay, not the result of an empirical study.

Sources and Further Reading

- Moderation team of r/gamedev: [r/gamedev Policy on AI Use](#). Primary source for the moderation team's position; not a survey of the community.
- Discussion on r/indiegames: [AI art in your game should be an instant ban from this sub](#). A single discussion thread, not representative.
- Hui, Xiang; Reshef, Oren; Zhou, Luofeng (2024): The Short-Term Effects of Generative Artificial Intelligence on Employment: Evidence from an Online Labor Market. *Organization Science*, 35(6), 1977-1989. DOI: [10.1287/orsc.2023.18441](#).
- Hui, Xiang; Reshef, Oren (2025): [Is generative AI a job killer? Evidence from the freelance market](#), Brookings, 8 July 2025. A publicly accessible explanation of the study by two of its authors.

2. Artists' Legitimate Objection

Generative AI is based on human-created content. Some training methods have used protected works without the individual consent of their creators. An image does not lose its protection merely because it is publicly available on the internet or linked in a dataset. The documentation for LAION-5B explicitly points out that the metadata it contains and the rights to the linked images are different things.

Whether use without individual consent is unlawful depends, however, on the applicable law and the specific circumstances. In its 2025 report, the US Copyright Office describes training uses that may qualify as "fair use" and others for which that is unlikely. This report is an analysis of US law, not a globally binding decision. The claims that "all training is theft" and that "anything on the internet may be used" are therefore equally sweeping.

The ethical question remains even where a use may be legally permissible. Artists publish their work to attract clients and an audience. The fact that the same work can contribute to building a system that subsequently competes for those clients creates an understandable conflict of interest. Patreon acknowledges this conflict: the company supports helpful AI applications while also calling for fair treatment and compensation for the creators of the training material.

Sources and Further Reading

- LAION (2022): [LAION-5B: A New Era of Open Large-Scale Multi-Modal Datasets](#), especially the section "License".
- U.S. Copyright Office (2025): [Copyright and Artificial Intelligence, Part 3: Generative AI Training](#), pre-publication version from May 2025. Particularly relevant: Section IV on fair-use analysis and Section V on licensing models. Government report, not a court judgment.
- Patreon (2025): [A real conversation about artificial intelligence](#), 14 March 2025. The company's position on AI, copyright, and compensation.

3. Why Prices and Self-Image Come Under Pressure

An image generator does not have to match a professional illustrator in every respect to change that illustrator's market. If the result is sufficient for a client and costs substantially less, the client's willingness to pay may shift. Hui and Reshef discuss this mechanism for high-quality services as well. Merely assuring artists that good craftsmanship will always be needed therefore does not answer their economic question. Good work must find a sufficient number of paying clients.

The effects are distributed unevenly, however. In their study of freelance job advertisements, Teutloff and his co-authors found declining demand for certain substitutable skills, but also growth in complementary fields such as chatbot development. This implies neither a general collapse of the labour market nor certainty that everyone affected can move easily into a new occupation.

My interpretation is that the economic conflict in creative work often touches a person's self-image. Someone who has spent years learning to draw may connect part of their identity with that skill. A sudden change in demand can therefore also be experienced as a devaluation of one's path through life. This is a possible explanation, not a diagnosis of individual AI critics. Ethical opposition can equally be justified without personal economic exposure.

Sources and Further Reading

- Hui, Xiang; Reshef, Oren (2025): [Is generative AI a job killer? Evidence from the freelance market](#), especially the sections on providers' experience and quality.
- Teutloff, Ole; Einsiedler, Johanna; Kässi, Otto; Braesemann, Fabian; Mishkin, Pamela; del Rio-Chanona, R. Maria (2025): Winners and losers of generative AI: Early Evidence of Shifts in Freelancer Demand. *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*, 235, Article 106845. DOI: [10.1016/j.jebo.2024.106845](#). [Open-access entry with manuscript at UCL](#).
- The paragraph on creative self-image is an explicitly identified interpretation by the author; the cited labour-market studies do not examine this psychological mechanism.

4. When Outrage Takes Over the Discussion

William Brady and his co-authors used Twitter data and experiments to examine how moral outrage can be reinforced by social feedback. Positive reactions increased the likelihood of further expressions of outrage. People also took their cues from their group's visible norms of expression. The study does not examine an anti-AI movement or a dungeon-crawler community. It offers a possible mechanism for the escalation of online debates.

Applied to the conflict over AI, the following development appears plausible to me: a specific question about training data or quality becomes a judgment about the whole person. The label "AI user" is then enough. Differences between working methods disappear, and anyone who allows an exception may have to justify their group membership. This application is my interpretation; it was not directly tested by the cited study.

In my own environment, the conflict affects r/DRPG, r/dungeoncrawler, and other game forums, among others. I have seen the suspected use of AI images displace discussion of Lathmar and other games and provoke personal attacks. My Reddit block list has now reached three figures. After an earlier article, creative people on Patreon also blocked me; one even refunded the full six months of my membership. D

It is not possible to infer reliably from these experiences whether the opponents there form a majority or a minority. There are no representative data. A vocal group can nevertheless have a major influence on the perceived tone of a discussion even without a proven majority position. My conclusion is therefore this: I will not readily allow particularly active commenters to tell me that they speak for the entire player base.

Sources and Further Reading

- Brady, William J.; McLoughlin, Killian; Doan, Tuan N.; Crockett, Molly J. (2021): How social learning amplifies moral outrage expression in online social networks. Science Advances, 7(33), eabe5641. DOI: [10.1126/sciadv.abe5641](https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.abe5641). [Study description and abstract at Yale](#).
- Personal source: Michael, devlog Inner Values, [Inner Values | Lathmar: The Fallen Depths on Patreon](#)
- This essay has no reliable survey of majority opinion in r/DRPG or r/dungeoncrawler. It explicitly makes no corresponding factual claim.

5. Helping Shape Change Creates Agency

Economic historians study AI as a possible general-purpose technology, comparable in its breadth of application to steam power, electricity, or information technology. Nicholas Crafts stresses the importance of complementary investment, organisational change, and time lags. Great technical potential does not automatically and immediately produce broad prosperity.

Concrete studies show that AI can already be useful. Brynjolfsson, Li, and Raymond found productivity gains from the use of an AI assistant in customer service, particularly among less experienced employees. This is a finding from a specific business environment. It does not prove a corresponding benefit for every creative activity, but it contradicts the idea that AI is exclusively a machine for low-quality mass content.

My conclusion is clear: anyone who is fundamentally unwilling to learn about these tools risks losing room to act. Helping to shape change also means examining providers critically, setting limits, and demanding better rules. Rejection alone does not offer a reliable strategy for a changing market. Nor does using AI guarantee success. Learning improves the conditions for success but replaces neither judgment nor a viable business model.

Sources and Further Reading

- Crafts, Nicholas (2021): Artificial intelligence as a general-purpose technology: an historical perspective. Oxford Review of Economic Policy, 37(3), 521-536. [DOI: 10.1093/oxrep/grab012](https://doi.org/10.1093/oxrep/grab012).
- Brynjolfsson, Erik; Li, Danielle; Raymond, Lindsey R. (2025): Generative AI at Work. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 140(2), 889-942. [DOI: 10.1093/qje/qjae044](https://doi.org/10.1093/qje/qjae044). [Freely accessible working-paper version](#); the figures cited refer to this version.
- Agrawal, Ajay K.; Gans, Joshua S.; Goldfarb, Avi (2023): [Similarities and Differences in the Adoption of General Purpose Technologies](#), NBER Working Paper 30976. [DOI: 10.3386/w30976](https://doi.org/10.3386/w30976).
- The recommendation to help shape change actively is the author's conclusion, not a scientifically established prediction of individual winners and losers.

6. Our Attitude Shows in Our Work

For Lathmar, I derive a self-assured attitude from this. I am developing a game and reporting on it in the devlog. The mechanics of the NPCs, for example, represent work that is barely visible in a screenshot. A suspicion about the origin of an image does not answer whether those mechanics work.

I do not want to present myself as a victim. I consider understandable criticism carefully; I must reject personal attacks in anonymous forums. My position is more convincing where we discuss matters objectively while others resort to insults. This does not imply moral superiority over every AI sceptic. The difference lies in conduct. A reasoned criticism deserves a response; an insult creates no claim on my attention.

Responsibility also includes the choice of tools. Adobe states, for example, that it trains its own Firefly models on licensed and public-domain content and compensates participating Stock contributors. This statement by the manufacturer is not an independent seal of approval for every application. It does, however, show why specific training foundations should be examined instead of treating all systems as identical.

I will continue to develop my project, explain my decisions, and have them reviewed by my testing community. No one has to support Lathmar. Anyone who asks a factual question deserves a serious answer. Anyone who insults me does not thereby gain a say over my work and is blocked. This position is my own standard, against which my conduct must also be measured.

Sources and Further Reading

- Adobe: [Our approach to generative AI with Adobe Firefly](#), undated company statement, accessed 8 October 2026. The information applies to the Adobe Firefly models described and must not be generalised to every third-party model available within Adobe applications.